Minnesota
by Spill Major

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(*Open to a row of airline seats. Two passengers getting settled: a young woman and a larger, older man*.)

Girl: You're on my seatbelt.

Guy: I'm President Grover Cleveland.

Girl: President Grover Cleveland, you're on my seatbelt. (*He leans up so she can get it*.)

Guy: I wonder if they'll give me two bags of peanuts.

Girl: You *are* a President.

Guy: It doesn't go very far, anymore.

Girl: Oh. President Grover Cleveland?

Guy: Please, Call me Steve.

Girl: President Steve, why are you flying to Minneapolis?

Guy: I've never been there.

Girl: Were they a state then?

Guy: Huh?

Girl: When you were President.

Guy: How old do you think I am?

Girl: Oh.

Guy: Although I miss the days when locomotives were preferred to these crazy flying stage coaches. (*an awkward silence*)

Girl: (*suddenly*) President Steve - aren't you dead?

Guy: (*looking at her for the first time*) I thought so too. (*He wants to say more, but can think of nothing. After a long pause, he speaks again.)* So, why are *you* hurtling towards Minneapolis in the belly of this winged metal beast?

Girl: I go to law school at the University of Minnesota.

Guy: Yes I've heard they let women into the Bar these days. Tell me something,

Girl: Yes?

Guy: Are you all hardcore lesbians, or are some of you just trying it out?

Girl: I was thinking of giving you my peanuts before, but now my lesbo ass is keeping those nuts.

Guy: I wouldn't think you'd be interested in my nuts.

Girl: *What?*

Guy: I was married to a woman younger than you.

Girl: And what happened to her?

Guy: You know women. They sort of… get old. Then you lose track of them. Like loose change.

Girl: That's awful.

Guy: Speaking of loose change… (*he digs around in his pockets*) who is this bastard on the dime? Looks like a real dweeb.
Hey, can I give you ten cents for your peanuts?

Girl: (*She snaps.*) Ten cents! Ten cents will buy you one peanut, maybe an almond. They don't even give you meals on these things anymore – the nuts are all you get. I'm a college student, Mr. President – why do I keep calling you that – I'm a poor college student, those peanuts are the only thing I'm eating all day until I get back to my tub of ramen. But sure, even though you're probably some prick named Steve, I'll give you my peanuts. And since you seem pretty determined to suck me dry, is there anything else I can get you, Mr. President?

Guy: Pickled herrings.

Girl: What?

Guy: I perused a book entitled, "America's Great Leaders." It contained only one quote from me, in regards to cheese and pickled herrings. I could go for some right now. Apparently they're the legacy I worked so hard for.

Girl: Too bad you didn't work a little harder. They might have given you some extra peanuts.

Guy: The federal government should not interfere in the economy. And young ladies should not be rude to former Presidents.

Girl: I don't have to do anything but sit next to you. I don't care if you're Millard Effing Fillmore.

Guy: I told you it doesn't go far anymore.

Girl: Stop it. Stop. And to think, when we were boarding, I wanted to compliment you on your great hair weave.

Guy: It's not a weave. It's a hair system.

Girl: What's the difference… an expensive wig is still a wig.

Guy: I would ask you to be respectful.

Girl: What?

Guy: Those words you use to describe my hair system were inappropriate.

Girl: Are you serious?

Guy: That word – the "w" word. That's hate speech. To someone who suffers like me. Baldness is a disease. It should be legally protected, I think.

Girl: You know what I think? That I'm going to stop talking to you, and then never make the mistake of doing so again in my life.

Guy: (*staring at her*) Fascinating.

Girl: *What*?

Guy: You're sure you're not a lesbian?

Girl: So what if I was.

Guy: I.. never thought of an answer to that.

Girl: Are you playing a prank on me? Is this on Candid Camera. I swear, Justin Bieber pops out from the bathroom, I will take this plane down.

Guy: Justin Bieber? Who is that?

Girl: Someone who is already more famous than you ever were.

Guy: I was President!

Girl: When the population was about 70 million. Now we have over 300. Justin Bieber probably has 70 million followers on Twitter.

Guy: I don't know what any of those words mean and I would prefer not to.

Girl: Look, I don't need this. I have enough on my mind.

Guy: Why are you going to Minnesota?

Girl: (she looks at him, then realizes it's hopeless to not say anything.) My cats died.

Guy: A great loss. Our nation mourns with you.
Girl: Do not make fun of me right now. Do not. I loved those cats. Both of them got hit by ice cream trucks in the same week.

Guy: I am not sure why someone would put ice cream in a truck, but that still sounds like a particularly cruel coincidence.

Girl: The first one, I cried. The second one, I laughed. I was beyond sad. I was away at law school, and now I feel like I need to see my parents because...

Guy: Because you need to face the cruelties of fate with the people you love.

Girl: I don't know why. No, not that. I just want to be home.

Guy: That's why I'm hoping my trip is short. I'd like to get back to my home. (Girl says nothing, even though Guy expects it.) You know, the White House.

Girl: Oh give it up already.

Guy: Last night I was in the Oval Office until 2 in the morning, vetoing bills on war pensions… or was that last night? What have I done these past few days? (*He looks to her.*) Remember, I just gave that speech on tariffs… (*He realizes that he looks foolish.*) No, maybe that hasn't made it to the papers yet. Maybe not. Is this my first term or second?

Girl: The years in-between.

Guy: You did recognize me!

Girl: I've heard of more than pickled herrings. (*pause*) President Cleveland, are you sure you're not some guy named Steve?

Guy: I am not. Steve lives in Minneapolis. President Cleveland, I mean, I have never been there.

Girl: Why change your name, then?

Guy: I was starting to think that people didn't like me anymore.

Girl: Maybe you should pretend to be Steve for the rest of the flight.

Guy: Why?

Girl: So you feel like you're going home. (*Silence, for a bit.*)

Guy: I’d still like a second bag of peanuts.

Girl: When they come, you can have mine.

Guy: And you will have many thanks of a grateful nation.

Girl: I’ll settle for the thanks of a grateful Steve. (*Lights down*)